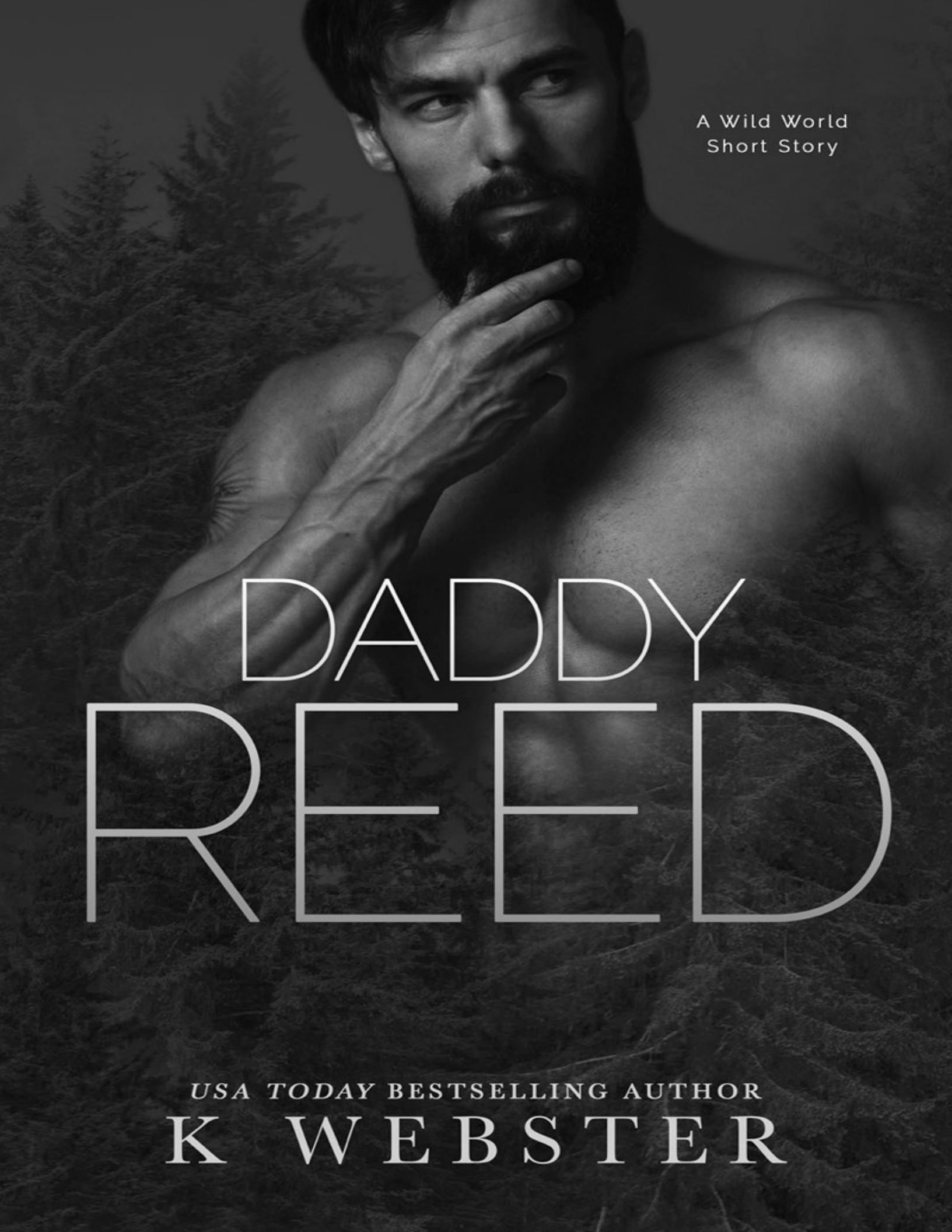




A Wild World
Short Story

DADDY REEF

USA TODAY BESTSELLING AUTHOR
K WEBSTER

Daddy Reed

A Wild World Short Story

K Webster

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Daddy Reed (A Wild World Short Story)

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Note to Reader

Daddy Reed takes place around twenty years after [The Wild](#) (give or take a few years). Their original love story can be found in [The Wild](#). This 10k word short story gives you a glimpse into their happily ever after and a peek at their many children to gear you up for the next book in this Wild World called [The Untamed](#).

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Wild World Books

[The Wild](#)

[The Free](#)

Daddy Reed (Short Story)

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WILD WORLD VIEW



JAMISON HOMESTEAD CLOSE-UP



Chapter 1

Reed

She's still my daughter.

After all these years and all the children we've created together, Devon is still my child. The little girl I raised turned out to be a fierce, loving, and intelligent woman. Daddy's little girl. Sometimes, like now, I can almost forget she's my wife and get lost in a time decades before when she didn't call me Reed. When I was just Dad. Her protector, her disciplinarian, her provider.

It's always when she sleeps.

Her features aren't that of a woman who recently turned forty. There are no wrinkles or crow's feet at the corners of her eyes. And, despite giving birth so many times, she's still toned and trim. When she sleeps, though, her golden blonde hair sweeping over her rosy cheek and her plump lips parted, she's angelic.

She's fucking perfect.

It probably makes me a little sick in the head, but I miss being her dad. The dynamics of our relationship changed when we came to Alaska. I'd been trying desperately to connect with my wife at the time—Devon's mother—and us picking up to permanently move here was supposed to solve that.

I was wrong.

Sabrina pulled away even further as time went on. The death of our son, and Devon's twin, Drew, was a devastating blow to Sabrina as a mother. She never really could move on. Sabrina lived in the misery of her aching heart, leaving me and Devon to heal together.

Because of this, my daughter and I grew close, like any typical familial relationship. It was normal. We were normal.

The move to Alaska changed everything.

We lost yet another vital member of our family and were then forced to survive.

Things evolved.

We evolved.

What happened between us back then. . . It shouldn't have happened. I fucked up and allowed her to control me by my dick. And she did. Devon whittled away at my self-control until there was nothing left.

I took her.

I made her fucking mine.

Daughter and lover.

Child turned eventual wife.

Our relationship only makes sense out here. In the wild. Where we're free to love each other despite society's rules. We don't belong in town. The few times we've gone there with Atticus for supplies or other reasons, it always became clear within the first few minutes.

My other children hate when we leave home.

Sure, they love the goodies Atticus and Eve bring them on their visits, but I don't miss the terror in their eyes whenever they experience the big, bad world.

Hell, my eldest son Rowdy went to town a few years ago to get a taste of that life. It scarred him in ways he refused to speak about. He came back hardened and jaded. My crazy, laughing, silly boy transformed into this

twenty-two-year-old quiet beast, always stewing and mentally suffering from whatever fucked him up out there.

Devon stirs, her brows pinching together, and my attention is drawn back to her. With a house full of kids, she rarely gets a break. Dawson, not even a year old, sleeps in our room, so even the nights are consumed by the needs of our children. Thankfully, tonight, he's sleeping soundly.

Whatever held her hostage in her dreams has gone away, and her features, illuminated by the moonlight pouring in through the window, become serene once more. My fingers crave to comb through her hair and comfort her or press my mouth to hers, but I don't dare wake her.

My mind drifts back to our children. All eight of them are perfect in their own ways. Even Rowdy, despite whatever hurt him before. They're all unique individuals with silly quirks, strong personalities, and intense love for each other. I was pleased to know that long after I'm gone, they'll have each other for decades to come.

Devon stiffens, and then her eyes pop open. I swear, even in sleep, she never fully relaxes. Always in mama bear mode.

"Hey, Pip," I murmur, low to not wake Dawson.

Her lips curl into a smile. "Hey, handsome."

I smirk at her compliment. I'm glad she still finds me attractive despite our twenty-three-year age gap. Sixty-three isn't exactly young.

"Handsome?" I tease. "I think you meant old."

Devon props up on one elbow to study me, a serious expression on her face. "I meant handsome. You're hot, Reed. The gray in your hair totally does it for me."

My dick thickens at the saucy grin she flashes. I may be in my early sixties, but I cannot get enough of this woman hence our many, many children. In fact, as soon as Dawson gets old enough and Devon gives me the "put a baby in me" eyes, I'm going to fuck her until we add a ninth kid to the roster.

“Don’t look at me like that,” I warn, voice barely a whisper.

“Like what?” she taunts.

“Like you need a midnight dick-down.”

“I *do* need a midnight dick-down.” She sits up in bed and begins peeling my oversized T-shirt from her body. Small, perfectly sized tits jiggle with the movement. “Question is, can you handle it, old man?”

There’s nothing old about my dick. It’s thick and hard as granite, barely confined in my boxers. I’ll never not want to fuck this woman. She’s my everything, and consuming her every chance I get gives me life.

I’m eager to toss her onto her back and wrench her thighs apart so I can feast on her pretty pussy, but I can tell she’s up to something different tonight. She wants to lead, so I will follow.

I’d follow her into the abyss and through the gates of hell if it meant being with her forever.

She shimmies out of her panties and then bites her bottom lip. I marvel at her absolute beauty. It’s more than just her appearance. It’s her. Devon radiates with strength and love that I’m ravenous for. Always starved for every piece she’ll gift to me.

Because she’s a tease, she straddles my waist rather than divesting me of my underwear and sits her ass right on my aching cock. Her small hands slide over my firm pectoral muscles, blue eyes locking on mine. Then with incredible slowness, she starts to grind her ass and pussy over my dick.

A feral groan rasps out of me.

I hope to fuck I don’t wake the baby.

Soon, I forget about anything other than the way she feels as she rubs me with years of perfected practice. I could come just like this, dry-humping my daughter-turned-wife, and it would be fantastic.

My girl, though, likes to be filled.

She likes it when I lose control and claim her like we’re two animals mating.

Rough. Urgent. Possessive.

Her fingernails gently rake down over my abs. Sure, I'm an old-ass man, but living in the wild forces you to remain fit. Hard, daily physical labor makes sure of it. I know that had we stayed at our old home, I'd probably have a belly like most normal men my age. I sure as hell wouldn't have the stamina to keep up with the sexual needs of a woman twenty-plus years my junior.

Pre-cum dampens the cloth of my boxers. She toys with me by adding her own wetness to it, rubbing and rubbing and rubbing in continuous circles. The wicked grin she shoots me tells me she's enjoying prolonging this.

She wants to see how long I'll suffer before I snap.

My ego begs me to hold out for as long as I can. To remind her I'm a man who can handle a little girl like herself.

But my animalistic need to overpower her and take what I need always wins out.

Her gasp is audible but silent enough to not wake the baby when I toss her off me. My palm itches to punish her for teasing me. All too easily, I flip her onto her stomach, gaining access to her fleshy ass. Smacking her might wake Dawson, so I settle for teasing her right back. I plant myself between her legs, pull her ass cheeks apart, and eat her sweet pussy from behind.

She hates when I do this because my nose rubs against her asshole, which she thinks is gross.

I don't give a damn. Her asshole is perfect and definitely not gross. Everything about her is perfect.

"Such a bad girl," I murmur against her sensitive flesh. "I should fuck you here to teach you a lesson." I suck on my finger and then press into her tight asshole. "Is that what you want, Pip?"

Her moans are muffled by the pillow, and she wriggles at my touch. My finger slides in and out of her hole as I lick at the arousal leaking from her cunt. It amazes me that a woman can have so many children and her vagina still be as perfect as it was when I took it the first time.

Memories of taking her virginity have me growling against her pussy. God, I was so terrified and overwhelmed back then. I'd fucked her anyway, but the morality of the situation royally screwed with me.

Now, I don't give a damn.

Daughter, wife, life partner, best friend.

Devon fits into so many boxes that all the lines that blurred once before have become one beautiful, glaringly obvious one.

She's mine.

In all the ways.

When I slip my finger out of her ass, eager to put my dick in there instead, she pushes up on her knees and wriggles her butt at me.

"Fuck me, Reed."

"Oh, I'm going to fuck this tight ass," I agree, grinning down at her. Unable to keep from doing it, I smack her ass cheek hard enough she yelps. "Daddy's going to make you cry."

She moans, clearly just as turned on by our relationship dynamics as I am. "Not there. My pussy."

I shove my boxers down my thighs and take hold of my throbbing dick. She whimpers when I smack her pussy with it a couple of times. "Anything for you, Pip. Grab a condom."

Her ass presses back, making her pussy slide over the tip of my dick. "No."

"No?"

"I want you inside of me. Nothing between us."

A feral growl rumbles through me. "I'll get you pregnant, Devon. I always do."

“Don’t care,” she breathes. “Just want to feel you.”

My wife doesn’t have to tell me twice. The beast inside me roars with pleasure at the idea of planting a seed into her fertile body. Adding another smiling face to our sweet brood sounds like a slice of heaven to me.

Grabbing hold of her hips, I hoist her up, driving my dick deep into her hot cunt. Her body quakes, and her fingers grip the sheets like they might fly away. I piston my hips wildly, relishing in the slapping sounds our bodies make when we fuck. These moments alone, making love to my girl, are my favorite.

“Make yourself come, Pip. I want to feel your pussy milking me. You want another baby, beautiful, then fucking earn it.”

Her fingertips brush over my cock as she massages her clit. Such an obedient thing when I have her at my mercy. And, because she’s talented with her fingers, it doesn’t take but a few more of my own thrusts for her to orgasm. She cries out, muffling the sound into the bed, and her pussy clenches around me.

“Fuck,” I rasp out. “Fuck, you feel so good.”

Pleasure surges through me, settling in my nuts and then pulsating through my dick as I shoot rope after rope of thick cum into her needy body. Her pussy continues to constrict around me, squeezing out every drop she’ll need to make a baby.

Her whole body trembles, and she collapses, becoming boneless after my ravishing. I keep my dick pressed in her, holding her bottom half up with my hands to keep all of my jizz inside of her.

“Da.”

Me and Devon both freeze.

“Dadadadadada.”

Devon tries to smother her laughter but is unable to. Her giggles burst out, which has Dawson hollering with glee.

Every single time we fuck, we wake one of the kids up. Our after-sex cuddle times are a thing of the past. Hell, I can't remember the last time I just held her after.

Damn kids.

I'm grinning as I yank my pillow over and stuff it under her stomach. "Stay, Pip. Just like this."

She groans, but my good girl doesn't move. I grab a discarded towel from the floor and dab her clean before swiping our juices off my body. Dawson continues to laugh and babble as I yank my boxers up.

I saunter over to his crib and scoop my son up. He smells like Devon, which I love.

"You were almost a cockblocker," I say, playfully grumbling at him. "Almost."

Dawson cackles like I'm the most hilarious person on the planet.

"Yeah, yeah," I tease. "You're still my favorite child."

But that's a lie.

Devon will *always* be my favorite.

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Chapter 2

Devon

My children worry me.

Sure, like most moms I worry about them getting hurt or sick. With the younger kids, I definitely have a healthy amount of worry when it comes to that stuff. It's the older children, though, I worry most about.

Especially Raegan.

Raegan is my most difficult child. A daughter with a fighting spirit like her father. The girl can hunt and fish and build like the boys—a true pioneer princess of the wilderness. She's fearless and stubborn. One day, when she marries, her husband is going to have his hands full.

That girl has a mouth on her.

My God, does she ever.

I can't help but smile thinking about my daughter as I hang clothes on the line behind the house. Dawson is strapped to my back and chattering to himself. Kota and Declan are following their daddy around his workshop. At five and three, those boys are always in Reed's hair. Not that he ever gets annoyed. Destiny asked Rowdy to take her to the orchard since she's nearly blind and isn't allowed to go alone. Raegan's probably giving Ryder hell per usual or glued to Ronan's hip. It's a rare peaceful moment—one where I can get lost in my thoughts.

Raegan is still at the forefront of my mind.

She's nearly an adult. When she turns that magical age, she might find a way to leave us. To pick up and try her fate in town, like sweet Rowdy did. But knowing her, she'd thrive like he didn't.

Except she won't leave.

Not without Ronan.

My quiet, sensitive son still seems so young to me, even at nineteen. As a child, he'd always let his siblings do all the hollering and crying and sit without muttering a peep. Anything I ever asked of him, he'd do without argument. To this day, he does as he's told. Ronan is a gem and so different than his unruly sister. I'm thankful he has Ryder, despite being a year younger, to look after him.

Ryder, like his father, is protective to a fault. He thinks it's his duty to keep everyone in our family safe. Naturally, this means he and Raegan butt heads endlessly.

Sometimes I wish Raegan would connect with Destiny more. Sure, they share a bedroom, and only have three years separating them, but the two couldn't be more different. That's on Raegan. She pushes everyone but Ronan away.

Nagging worry gnaws at my gut as I finish the laundry. I scoop up the basket and make my way to the back door of the big house. Reed assures me I have nothing to worry about, but he doesn't see how Raegan moons over Ronan. One day, that adoration might turn into a crush.

And *that* can never happen.

I won't allow it.

It's probably hypocritical because of my and Reed's relationship. He's my father—the same father who read me stories way before I could read them myself, took me to my first day of kindergarten, and held me through my tears when my twin died. It's not fair for me to forbid my children from

loving each other in a way that goes beyond sibling love, knowing they're in the same situation I was in when my own feelings changed for my father.

Secluded.

Alone.

Sheltered from people and the outside world.

Still, I won't let it happen.

Thankfully, none of them have shown any interest in each other. Reed agrees the second one of them does, we'll have to nip it in the bud. Atticus and Eve are just a few hours away and will let them come stay with them if need be.

I'm feeling frazzled by the time I deposit the laundry basket where it goes and head toward the kitchen. Ronan stands at the sink munching on an apple. His glasses are slightly askew, and his hair is messy. Such a cute kid. One day, he'll find someone to appreciate how wonderful he is. Someone other than Raegan.

"Hey, Mom," Ronan says, wiping his chin with the back of his hand. "What's for dinner?"

Having six sons means someone is "starving" all the time. Usually, it's Ryder or Kota. But today, it looks like Ronan is the hungry one.

"Here, take your brother, and I'll get supper started," I say, swiveling to offer him my back. "He may need a diaper change."

Dawson squeals when he sees Ronan. The weight of my baby is soon lifted, and my aching shoulders thank me. I press a kiss to each of their foreheads before shedding the baby carrier and heading over to the pantry.

Our pantry is the best part of our house. Reed and I talked for hours when we planned out the build. My vision was for it to be huge—always filled with food to keep our family fed. The shelves are floor-to-ceiling, and it's roomy. Everyday foods—like breads, produce, and snacks for the kids—are housed toward the front. Eggs, dried meats, filtered and bottled water, and all the excess stuff remains in the back. At the very back of the pantry

is a door that leads outside and down to the root cellar, where we store potatoes, onions, turnips, carrots, and other fruits or vegetables.

Knowing there's enough to keep everyone's bellies filled through winter or slow game seasons is just one less thing I have to worry about.

I grab an armful of things I'll need for supper and make my way back into the kitchen. Dawson has stolen Ronan's apple and slobbers all over it as he attempts to eat it with his tiny teeth.

"It's his now," Ronan grumbles. "This kid drools a lot."

I smile as I start peeling potatoes. "All you kids did at that age."

We chatter, just the two of us, about everything from the chickens to the book Ronan is currently reading while Dawson sucks on the apple. He tells me a story of aliens and the strange world they live on. By the time he finishes regaling me, I have the potatoes boiling, and I'm pulling the fish fillets from the refrigerator.

"Hopefully Atticus thinks to bring us some baking soda," I grumble as the stinky fish smell wafts over me. "Or more candles. I could use more candles."

"I'm hoping he brings more books than last time," Ronan says. "I went through the last stack way too fast."

After I season the fish and slide the trays into the oven, I sit at the kitchen table for a quick rest. Ronan's staring out the front window. I follow his gaze to where Raegan is chasing after Ryder, who clearly has something she wants. Those two just never stop.

"Had enough of those two today?" I ask, gesturing at the window.

Ronan laughs. "Nah, just missed seeing my momma."

I smirk at him. He's always been my sweet boy who knows what to say in every situation. I'm proud of the wonderful man he's become.

"You excited to see Wild?" I arch a brow at him. "I know how much you adore him."

His cheeks turn red, and he fidgets in his seat, absently playing with Dawson's hair. "Yeah, he's cool."

Wild is a lot of things.

And he definitely likes to think of himself as cool.

He's a mess, is what he is. I've observed the way he picks at Raegan whenever he's here. I won't lie and say I don't secretly root for them to fall for each other, but that won't happen anytime soon.

Raegan can't stand Wild.

I'm about to go back over to the stove to check the potatoes when Raegan bursts into the house. She hollers about Ryder and stomps into the kitchen.

"Mom! Do something about your bratty kid!"

I turn to find her standing in the kitchen, hands on her hips and tapping her foot incessantly. "Which one?"

She groans and rolls her eyes. Even when *she's* being the bratty kid, she's beautiful. A spitting image of her father. Me and Reed sure do make some pretty babies.

"Ryder, the rotten piece of sh—"

She's cut off by Ryder's booming voice. "Mom!"

Ronan shoots me an exasperated look. Never a dull moment with Ryder and Raegan. Never.

"What?" I call out, lifting a brow at a fuming Raegan. "I'm in here."

Ryder stalks into the kitchen, pushes past his sister, and stands right in front of me. He's strong, built of solid muscle, and towers over me. But tattling on his sister reminds me of when he was five.

"She kicked me," he growls, thrusting a finger at his sister.

"Raegan," I start, shooting her a frown. "Why did you kick your brother?"

"Because he's a thief!" she bellows. "Stay out of my stuff, thief!"

Ryder growls. “For fuuuu-dge sake. I can’t steal what already belongs to me!”

“Nice save,” I mutter, side-eyeing him for almost dropping an F-bomb in my kitchen. “And this had better not be about that stupid knife again.”

“It’s always about the knife,” Ronan chimes in. “Maybe I should take it.”

Ryder and Raegan bark a vehement “No,” in unison.

“The knife is about to go in the river,” I threaten. “Now, both of you get washed up and help me set the table for supper.”

“Dad needs me,” Ryder blurts out, taking off out of the kitchen at a breakneck speed.

I shake my head and then pin Raegan with a hard stare. “Don’t you dare.”

After a small hissy fit, she finally relents and passes out plates.

This house is nothing but chaos, and I wouldn’t have it any other way.

“I can’t believe you hid a bag of marshmallows from me,” I grumble to Reed with narrowed eyes. “That’s grounds for divorce.”

He jerks his head my way but still manages to help Declan put his marshmallow on his stick. “What’s that, wifey?”

I pat Dawson’s bottom, happy he finally fell asleep after a mini meltdown after supper. Soon, I’ll take him inside to put him down for the night. Until then, I’ll continue to enjoy poking at my bear.

“What’s a divorce?” Kota asks, cocking his head to the side.

“Something your momma isn’t allowed to have,” Reed growls. “Right, babe?”

I shrug my shoulders. “I mean, if you hold out on me when it comes to sweets, I might have to get one. That’s just rude.”

He flashes me a dark look that promises a palm to my ass later. I shiver despite the roaring fire going in the pit. He’s momentarily distracted when

Declan starts crying because his marshmallow caught fire.

We come out to the fire pit often in the evenings. Of course, the older kids are too cool to hang out with their parents, but Destiny and the three younger boys enjoy this time together.

“Here,” Destiny says from nearby. “You can have mine, Deck.”

Declan snuffles before running over to his sister. She helps as he messily eats the marshmallow. I’m still grinning at them when a shadow looms over me. Reed holds a blackened marshmallow on the end of a stick just out of reach.

“That for me, Daddy?”

His nostrils flare, and his tongue runs along his bottom lip. If we didn’t have an audience, he’d probably toss me over his shoulder and take me away to do dirty things.

“You can’t ever leave me,” he says, eyes hotter than the fire. “Ever, Pip. You’re mine. Always.”

I melt under his possessive words. “Next time I get my period, don’t hold out on me. You know I love marshmallows.”

A slow, sinister grin curls his lips up. “Beautiful, you’re not getting your period for a long-ass time.”

He’s so sure of himself and his baby-making skills.

“I’m serious,” I say, standing my ground. “I can handle a lot, but if you ever withhold marshmallows from me again, you’ll see my breaking point.”

“Noted,” he says with a smirk. He leans in over the baby to kiss my lips. “Now eat this before you lose your shit.”

He plucks the gooey marshmallow off the stick and then crams it into my mouth. I glower at him despite the wonderful taste. When he smears the sticky residue from his fingers on the tip of my nose, I’m the one shooting him a threatening glare.

“You’re an asshole,” I mutter low enough the kids don’t hear.

“And you defied the law to be with me.”

Touché.

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Chapter 3

Reed

I'm not eager to leave my bed. Not when Devon clings to me, body hot and slick with sweat. Early morning sex is both the best and the worst. The best because the house is quiet, and the moment is all ours while we lose ourselves to the passion that always burns between us. It's the worst, though, because once I've fucked my beautiful girl, I'm too relaxed to do shit.

And I have too much shit to do today.

With summer nearly over, there's a never-ending list of projects to be completed before it starts getting cold. The boys will help hunt and trap game to stock up for winter, and the girls will do their part harvesting what they can from the gardens, but those things take time. Long days from sunup to sundown. No time for lazing around with my naked wife.

Still, I don't move.

I stroke my fingers up and down her bare arm, nuzzling my nose in her hair. Her scent is always the same. From the moment I first held her in my arms as my responsibility, my treasure, and my little girl to now. She's my partner, my lover, my everything. I love Devon more than words could even express.

She's not some drug I'm addicted to.

Devon is the very air I breathe. She's life and joy and pleasure all wrapped into a beautiful package. Taking her all those years ago was necessary. I had to have her to survive. And because of that, I'm still here. A man past my prime but feral and strong and protective like a beastly creature of the forest.

Without her, I'd have died long ago because I'd be incomplete. Half a person. Fucking empty and soulless.

Her thigh is casually draped over mine. My dick is no longer erect but still wet and dripping from being inside her. The warm air is quickly drying me, and soon I'll be sticky with the remnants of our cum.

I need to get up and clean us.

A soft creak has both of us stiffening. I'm unable to locate the sheet to cover our nudity and post-sex state before one of our children steps into the room.

In the dim, early morning light, I sigh in relief. It's just Destiny. Though she can see shapes, there's no way she will get a detailed glimpse of us or what we've been up to.

"Daddy?"

Devon sits up, snatching the sheet from the floor, and swoops it over the both of us. I sit up on my elbows and take in Destiny's bedraggled state. She looks so much like Devon at that age. My heart squeezes with love.

"Yes, baby girl?"

She slowly makes her way over to us, steps measured and slow because of her disability, unlike the rest of our crazy children. When her knees hit the foot of our bed, she frowns. "Raegan's not in our room."

All warmth leeches from my body as a cold chill settles in my bones. "Did you check the couch or the bathrooms?"

Devon is already out of bed, throwing on her nightgown. "So help me if she's in Ronan's cabin. . ."

My chest tightens at the thought of catching her in bed with her brother. I'd have to send him away because that shit can't happen.

"I'm sure she'll turn up around here somewhere," I grumble. "Pip, turn the house upside down. I'll check with the boys."

Minutes later, I'm fully dressed and storming out of the house toward the two cabins on the other side of our fenced-in property. I make a beeline for Ronan's cabin since Devon has her suspicions. Unlike Ryder's cabin, which has discarded boots scattered by his front door, Ronan's porch is immaculate.

Without warning, I fling open his door, ready to tear him and Raegan each a new asshole. Except, when I scan the bed, it's just Ronan. He jolts up with a terrified yelp and then grabs for his glasses on the table. Once they're on, he relaxes at seeing me.

"Dad? What's wrong?"

Guilt burns hot in my gut. My kids are good kids. Me and Devon are just paranoid, is all.

"We can't find Raegan," I say with a sigh. "Get dressed and help me look for her."

While he dresses, I step out and head next door. It's a long shot to think she'll be here, but I check anyway. Ryder is sprawled out on his stomach, buck-ass naked and lightly snoring.

"Where's your sister?" I bark out.

The kid sleeps like the dead and doesn't even flinch at my intrusion. I pick his jeans up from the floor and toss them at him. This finally wakes him, and he groggily looks my way.

"Get dressed, Ry. Raegan is missing."

He rolls his eyes and pulls the pillow over his head, grumbling about that being a good thing. At least I know she's not here.

There's only one other son's cabin she could be in, though they don't exactly have a close relationship. Still, I would be remiss if I didn't at least

check.

Twenty minutes later, I've left our property, gone down the cliffside stairs, and hiked over to me and Devon's old cabin where Rowdy lives. Our oldest needed his privacy and has it. However, if I find my damn daughter in his bed, heads are going to roll. Privacy will be a thing of the past.

His door is barred closed from the inside, so I beat on it with my fist until I hear heavy footsteps thudding my way. The wood-on-wood scraping sound can be heard as he removes the blockade, and the door opens.

I'm greeted with the barrel of his shotgun. He immediately lowers it when he registers that it's me.

"Dad? What are you doing here?"

Grunting, I shoulder past him into his space. This small home is where we raised the older kids before me and Atticus built the big house. It's where I took Devon's virginity and made her mine. It's also where I had to watch strangers assault her. Where I killed men for touching her and trying to take her away from me. Rowdy's cabin holds both good and bad memories for me.

I scan the entire space, including the cave inlet at the back of the cabin. Nothing.

Where the fuck is my daughter?

Annoyance and frustration begin to melt away as pure panic takes over. Did she run away? Did someone take her?

"Raegan's gone," I croak out, voice shaking with fear. "Help me find her."

I leave my stunned son to dress and hoof it back up to the big house, where I find a worried Ronan and a cranky Ryder standing by the gate.

"Did you find her?" Ronan asks, brows pinching together. "Mom said she's not in the house."

"No," I bark out. "I want you two searching everywhere. The equipment barn, the animal pens, the gardens, the orchard, the smokehouse, the—"

“Everywhere,” Ryder interrupts. “Got it. We’ll find her, Dad. Don’t worry.”

But I am worried.

With each passing moment that she’s gone, my stomach sours, and the worst imaginable scenarios start playing in my head like some kind of fucked up horror show.

What if she decided to go hunting and got attacked by a wild animal?

What if she’s dead?

I stop near the fire pit on the way to find Devon and dry heave. I can’t lose her. I can’t lose my daughter. Losing Devon’s brother Drew nearly killed me. My heart is too weak to go through something so horrific again.

Devon bursts out of the front door, Dawson in her arms. Her eyes are teary, and her cheeks are red. Seeing the pure panic in her expression has me dry heaving again. Kota and Declan pop up behind Devon and gape at me.

This time, acidic bile makes it up my throat, and I puke into the grass. All three boys begin to cry along with their mother, her sobs growing the loudest.

“Where is she, Reed?” Devon croaks. “Oh my God. We have to find her.”

I know this, but I can’t think. My brain is jumbled, and all I can see is her mangled body shredded to bits by a fucking bear.

“Do you think someone took her?” Devon asks, voice going shrill. “What if they stole my baby from me? What if they hurt her?”

Devon was Raegan’s age when she was brutally raped by those monsters. It nearly broke her. I had to nurse my girl back to a healthy mental state, and it was no easy feat. Imagining such terrible shit happening to Raegan is enough to have me collapse to my knees. The world goes dark around me.

Reed. Reed. Reed. Reed. Reed.

Devon's chanting voice gets smaller and further away as the darkness closes in around me.

Smack!

Pain rips me from the void, and I snap my head up to find Devon glowering at me, hand shaking and poised to smack me again.

"Breathe, goddammit. I can't lose you, too," she shrieks. "You're having a panic attack, Reed, but I need you to get it together."

On her command, I suck in a long breath, filling my oxygen-starved lungs. Tears prickle in my eyes, but I quickly blink them away. Devon is right. My family needs me. They need me to hunt down our little girl wherever she may be and bring her home.

I can do this.

I will find her.

Shakily, I rise to my feet and give my wife a clipped nod. I make my way into the house to locate a weapon. If I encounter any adversaries on my hunt, I will kill them without a second's hesitation. Anything to protect my child.

By the time I exit the big house, the entire family—aside from Raegan—is gathered by the fire pit. Each one of us wears a worried expression. I scrub a palm over my face, noting my fingers still smell like Devon. Her scent calms me and gives me the strength to continue on.

"Rowdy, check down by the river and over at Eve's old place." I point toward the river and gesture at the fence near the goat pen. "Ronan, check all the lookout posts. Ryder, you can search all her favorite hangout spots outside the fence, and I'll check the west side woods. Meet back here in an hour if you haven't found her."

We all scatter, and I trot out the gate.

The sun is beginning to peek through the trees, signaling that morning is officially here. I'm thankful for the added light, as it'll make our search that much easier.

And if we find her dead body?

I'll be able to see every gruesome detail on full display, glittering in the sunlight.

Don't think about that shit, man.

I continue to prowl through the woods, listening hard for any human-like sounds amongst the increasingly noisy forest as the birds begin to greet the day with their chirps. When I come to one of our first deer blinds, I pause to look for anything that might give me any clues.

Nothing.

It's times like these—when I feel so out of control—that I long for civilization. Back when we had a city home and a pool and neighbors and a fucking car. If we weren't living off the grid, I could call the police and have them aid me in searching for my daughter.

All I have is my family.

We will find her.

We have to.

A life without Raegan isn't one I can live.

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Chapter 4

Devon

They'll find her.

They have to.

I want to be with them, scouring the woods looking for my strong-willed daughter, but the younger kids need me right now. It's past time for breakfast, and they're getting crabby.

"I can cook the eggs, Mom," Destiny offers. "Or I can go outside and look for Rae. Whatever I can do to help. I'm old enough."

Destiny is such an angel. She's the complete opposite of Raegan and a heck of a lot easier to parent.

"Helping wrangle these little ones is perfect." I smooth my palm over her silky blonde head and then scurry over to the skillet to scramble the eggs. "I'll get some food in their bellies, and then we can look some more."

Despite my outwardly calm demeanor, my nerves are brittle, and my stomach won't stop clenching with worry. Not knowing where one of my kids are is sickening. This isn't some teenage runaway situation. My kids are happy here. Not one of them would run away. Not even Raegan.

Something bad has happened.

I feel it in my gut.

As I scramble the eggs, tuning out the chattering of the kids playing in the living room, my mind drifts to the past. When I was her age. When my

safety was stripped from me.

They came into our home.

Burst through the door, held my father down and forced him to watch while they. . . A shudder ripples through me. It's been so long since that horrible day, but it still feels so fresh.

Bruising fingers and barked threats.

Rancid breath.

Utter helplessness and absolute fear.

And there was the pain. Soul-shattering and relentless. They were inside me—taking and taking and taking.

A wretched sob crackles from my throat, startling me from the past back into the present. I swear I can almost smell their body odor, lingering like a foul cloud, filling every inch of my lungs. When I suck in a deep breath of air, the scent of cooking eggs replaces the remembered stench. I shakily dump some salt into the yellow fluff, doing my best to focus on the now to keep myself grounded.

Dad saved me.

Reed saved me.

Not right then, because they had the upper hand. Later. He saved me over and over again later with his continuous love. His unending desire to bring me joy. There was no peace in his eyes until he avenged me, making their murders brutal and painful.

I sniffle, swiping at my wet cheek with the back of my hand. One thing's for sure. I have to compose myself before I feed my babies. They'll sense my quiet desperation to find Raegan and the fear of what could happen to her. It'll upset them, and I need my children to be happy.

Always but especially now.

Quickly, I turn off all memories and plate up the cooked eggs. There are still muffins left over from yesterday's baking, so I add them and some fruit to their plates. Breakfast is served. Just barely.

I'm too sick to my stomach to eat, so I take Dawson from Destiny and sit him in his highchair. He's extra fussy, but as soon as I get a jar of sweet potatoes open and he gets his first bite, he settles down. I also sprinkle some eggs on his tray so he can play with and eat them while I feed him the potatoes.

My mind is back on images of Raegan. Except, instead of Reed watching those men rape me, it's me in our old cabin watching them hurt my baby girl. The emotional punch to the gut has me dropping the spoon poised at Dawson's mouth. It clatters noisily, splattering orange goo all over both him and me.

"Oh good, scrambled eggs. I'm starving."

The voice has me freezing, wondering if I'm imagining things. It feels more real—sharper than my memories of my past.

Whirling around, I locate the person belonging to the nonchalant voice. Like a vision come to life, my daughter prances into the dining room like nothing is amiss.

It takes me a second for reality to set in.

She's alive.

My daughter is alive and apparently well.

A squeal of ire rips from Kota when she snatches the muffin off his plate. Reagan is here—standing in our house—taunting her baby brother like nothing ever happened. Like our entire world wasn't just turned upside down and shaking while we all came tumbling out.

I'm out of my chair the next second and make it to her in an inhuman flash. I grab her shoulders and jerk her to me, burying my nose in her pine-scented hair.

This is real.

She's here.

"Mom?" Raegan asks, voice soft and unsure. "Are you okay?"

This snaps me out of my relief. I dig my thumbs in and push her away until she's at arm's length. Her hair is messy and tangled from the wind. She also smells like she hasn't had a chance to bathe.

"Where the hell have you been?" I demand, my words shrill and bordering on a shriek. "Goddamn you, child!"

Her lip curls up, and she affixes me with one of her usual defiant glares. "Good morning to you too, Mother."

The sass in this girl.

My God.

It takes everything in me not to kill her.

"Do you have any idea what you've put this family through?" I shake her shoulders to get her attention. "Your brothers and father are out there right now looking for your dead body!"

Raegan snorts out a laugh and then winces when she meets my furious stare. "S-sorry."

"Sorry isn't good enough!" I yell, causing the two youngest children to start crying. "I want to know where you were!"

She tries to jerk out of my hold, but I'm too upset to let her go. I thought I lost my baby. I thought she was gone. Hurt, raped, murdered. I can't fathom letting her out of my sight, not even for a second.

"Mom," Raegan whines. "It's fine."

So help me, I want to slap this child. I want to slap her into next week so she can physically feel the pain her family has felt while she was off doing whatever it was she was doing.

"It's not fine, Rae," I shout, ignoring the wails of Dawson. "You could have died!"

"It's not the first time I've been on the roof," she grumbles. "Don't you think you're being slightly overdramatic?"

The roof?

“You were on the roof of this house the whole time?” I close my eyes, breathing heavily through my nose to calm my fury. “Are you kidding me right now?”

“I go up there all the time.” She attempts to shrug her shoulders, but my vise-like grip prevents her from moving. “I just never fell asleep before.”

This unruly girl fell asleep on my roof.

Unbelievable.

“Go to your room,” I snap, body vibrating with anger. “I can’t deal with you right now.”

Her lips thin into a line, and her eyes flicker with the desire to argue, but whatever she sees reflected back has her backing down.

Good, because I’m going to do something regrettable if she doesn’t leave right now.

I release her and give a sharp shake of my head. “Destiny, keep an eye on the littles. I need to let your father know Raegan’s back.”

And grounded for life.

“We have to talk to her,” Reed says, stroking his fingers through my hair.

“You can’t leave her in her bedroom forever.”

“Maybe we should,” I huff. “It’s safer that way.”

He doesn’t have to remind me I was brutalized in my own bed. I’m just being stubborn, and we both know it. Thankfully, he doesn’t call me out and continues to pet me like his favorite kitten.

“She reminds me a lot of you,” Reed says softly, dodging my swat. “I’m being serious.”

“I was much better behaved.”

“True,” he admits, “but you loved the outdoors. You loved getting dirty and playing with your brother. Your treehouse was your favorite place to be.”

“I never got on the roof.”

“Had you been born and raised in the wilderness, you may not be able to say that.”

Ignoring that statement, I watch Dawson as he crawls over to where Declan and Kota are trying to build a block tower. Kota sharply instructs Declan to keep the baby away. That it’s his job. Our other boys are well-behaved, but something tells me Kota will be a troublemaker one day.

“I can talk to her,” Reed offers, playfully tugging my hair, “but. . .”

I sigh heavily and fill in the rest of his statement. “But she has you wrapped around her finger. No, it needs to be me.”

He stays quiet, watching the kids play as I stew in my thoughts. Finally, when I’ve pouted long enough, I sit up and frown at him.

“Parenting is supposed to get easier the older they get,” I mutter. “Right?”

Reed snorts and then mutters low enough only I can hear, “It wasn’t with you.”

I discretely flip him off and then kneel to press a kiss to his handsome mouth. “Fine. I’ll go. If you hear yelling, don’t come to rescue the prisoner.”

He winks at me and then manages to smack my ass when I pass by. Despite my thundering heart and Reed’s all-consuming love thrumming through me, I harness my anger and attempt to focus on the discussion with my daughter.

The door is closed, and when I push inside, I find Destiny and Raegan sitting beside each other, whispering lowly. Warmth blooms in my chest to see them acting like sisters who are best friends. Maybe something good can come out of this after all.

“Dez, honey, why don’t you go sit with Daddy while me and Rae have a talk.”

Destiny leans her head against Raegan’s before standing and walking my way. I pull her to me for a quick hug and then wait until she closes the

door behind her before speaking to Raegan.

“You could have broken your neck,” I say in exasperation. “Honestly, Rae, what were you thinking?”

She crosses her arms over her chest and glares my way. “I was thinking I’d like to stare up at the stars. I was thinking it’d be nice to have a peaceful moment to myself.”

There are plenty of places she could have escaped to get her privacy. And had she told us she needed it, we’d have allowed her to go. The whole disappearing act is where she went wrong.

“As long as you live here,” I tell her curtly, “you aren’t awarded those.”

“But Rowdy and Ryder and Ronan are? Why is that, Mom? Do you like them better?”

She pushes my buttons regularly just to see how far she can get away with disrespecting me. I don’t rise to her bait. Instead, I walk over to her bed and sit in Destiny’s vacated spot. Reaching down, I take her small hand in mine and squeeze.

“Your brothers are men now, but they’re not the problem here. The problem is you sneaking out and doing something dangerous alone. You could have been hurt.”

“But I wasn’t. I’m fine.”

“This time.”

She frowns at my ominous words. “Every time. I have been climbing trees far longer than I could walk.”

“It’s more than the roof and the sneaking out, Rae,” I grumble, shaking my head in frustration. “It’s everything outside of the fence that keeps us safe. It’s the worry that you were out there all alone. Something could have mauled you or worse yet. . .”

“Worse yet?” She laughs in disbelief. “What could be worse than a bear feasting on your intestines?”

The monsters of the human variety...

It's on the tip of my tongue to tell her about them. The monsters who hurt me. To put the fear in her heart of what could happen. But that would be a lot for a girl her age to hear and process. Not to mention, my curious child might continue asking questions. Questions that might have me confessing about her father and me.

"Bears would be terrible," I admit. "Let's just say there are people out there, and not everyone is good."

I know I'm being vague, but that's all she gets.

"I'm sorry I scared you," Raegan says through gritted teeth. "I really didn't mean to fall asleep on the roof."

I let go of her hand to wrap my arm around her. Tugging her to me, I hug her and inhale her familiar scent.

"Thank you," I say and then kiss her head. "But you're still grounded."

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Chapter 5

Reed

Raegan is safe.

The relief I feel is staggering. It was like every muscle in my chest that was responsible for making me breathe and holding my heart where it belongs was finally able to loosen. She had been home all along.

Devon was furious, but I find myself a little amused now that the fear is gone. Raegan's name should have been Rowdy because she's the one always stirring up trouble in this family. That girl loves the outdoors and wishes she were half-wolf.

"Another story," Kota begs, tugging at my beard and bringing me back to the present. "For Deck."

I glance over at his brother's bed. Declan is already passed smoothly out.

"Nice try, kiddo, but it's late." I bend down and kiss my second-most unruly child's head. "We'll do two stories tomorrow night."

He pouts, giving me his best pitiful, wounded animal expression, but I'm immune. I chuckle as I tuck him into bed. After turning off the lights, I leave the door cracked and then make my way down to the girls' room. Destiny is already asleep, sweet and angelic, while Raegan sits with her back against the wall on her bed, arms crossed and frowning.

“Hey, sunshine,” I greet softly as I enter the room.

Her bright smile peeks through, chasing away all the storm clouds in her eyes. “Hi, Daddy.”

I stride into her room and then sit down beside her, mimicking her position. She leans her head against my shoulder.

“I just wanted to look at the stars,” she murmurs. “It’s so pretty at night. I was relaxed, and I don’t know, just fell asleep. I didn’t do it to make Mom mad or to scare you.”

“I know. Your mother worries. You know this.”

“She’d strap me to her back right next to Dawson if she could,” she grumbles. “Imagine that.”

We both quietly laugh at that image. With Raegan being as big, if not bigger than Devon, that would be comical to witness.

“I’m not like her,” she says with a huff. “I’m like you. I don’t want to babysit all day. I want to be outside all the time. It’s not fair.”

Always the same with this wild girl.

She wants to be free.

“How about this?” I say slowly. “You promise to stay off the roof and stop sneaking out at night, and I’ll promise to get you out of the house more. Deal?”

Raegan jolts up, her grin blinding and brilliant. “You really mean that?”

“I really do.”

“Deal.” She grabs my hand and shakes it exaggeratedly before throwing her arms around me in a hug. “Thank you, Daddy. I love you.”

“Love you too, sunshine.”

Dawson sleeps on my bare chest, a small puddle of drool forming just under his mouth. Having as many babies as we’ve had over the years has definitely done its part in keeping me young. Hell, I could be a grandfather at my age, but instead, I have a teething baby sprawled out on me. Had we

stayed in California all those years ago, Devon would have married some college douchebag and given me grandkids decades ago. Thank fuck fate led us here instead.

Devon emerges from the bathroom, a towel wrapped around her body and her hair dripping with water. I'm reminded of the first time we bathed together in the river. How it was supposed to be so innocent and necessary but felt like the beginning of. . . everything. Time has passed by in a blink. It feels like it was only yesterday I watched her young tits as the river water lapped at them.

I'd been so thirsty to lap at them too.

She arches a brow at me and smirks. "What?"

"Just thinking about you."

Her lips curl into a pleased grin. Now that she knows all our children are safe, she's carefree and happy again. I love her in all the ways, but especially like this.

"Oh yeah?" she asks as she finger combs through her damp hair. "What about?"

"Your tits, naturally."

She snorts out a laugh that makes Dawson jolt. We both wince, wondering if he'll wake, but he doesn't. Finally, she says, "Is that all you think about?"

"I was also thinking about how you keep me young with all these babies." I gesture toward Raegan and Destiny's room. "Even when they drive you crazy, you still want more."

She saunters over to my side of the bed and gently picks Dawson up. "They're so perfect when they come out. It's hard to imagine them grown and rebellious. Motherhood is a trick."

I attempt to tug at her towel, but she sidesteps me, going to Dawson's crib. He doesn't stir as she places him down and covers him with his favorite rabbit fur blanket Devon made him.

Devon walks back over to me and, this time, lets me pluck her towel from her body. I grip her hips and haul her across me. Her legs straddle me, finding my cock already straining through my boxers.

“I could be a grandpa right now had our life gone differently,” I murmur, sliding my hands to her ass and squeezing. “Do you ever wonder about that life?”

She grinds her naked pussy against my dick, dampening my boxers with her arousal. “Not a life I’d want to live.”

“I’d just steal you from him anyway,” I tell her with a wolfish grin, reaching up to pinch one of her hardened nipples. “I’d come visit my grandkids, and while your husband was distracted, I’d drag you into the bathroom with me.”

Her teeth capture her bottom lip as she pins me with a smoldering stare. “He would hear us.”

I smirk, my dick throbbing at the fantasy we’re creating. “I would have to hold your mouth. Like this.”

She gasps when I roll, flipping us until she’s beneath me. My hand covers her supple mouth. Her heels dig into my ass, begging me to grind into her.

“Does your husband know you like to fuck your daddy?” I taunt, my voice a low growl. “Does he know all those kids actually belong to me?”

Her moan nearly undoes me. Devon is a filthy girl. I fucking love her.

“Shh, Pip,” I whisper. “I’m going to fuck you real good like your useless husband in the other room never can.”

I watch as her lashes flutter and her nostrils flare. She writhes beneath me, needing every bit of the friction I offer as I grind my cock against her.

“I’m going to fuck you fast and dirty, my sweet little girl.”

She moans louder, but I silence her with a warning glare. Her tits bounce with each ragged breath she attempts to suck in through her nostrils.

With my free hand, I grab the waistband of my boxers and jerk them down far enough to free my cock, dripping with pre-cum.

“Shh,” I croon, teasing her slick pussy with the crown of my cock. “I hear him calling for you.”

I push into her hot, wet body with one hard thrust that has her crying out. Her sounds are muffled by my hand. I’m soon lost in the fantasy right along with her, jealous of the fake husband who gets to have her all the time while I only get her on rare visits.

If this version of our lives ever existed, I’d gut that motherfucker. I’d slit his throat, kidnap my daughter and her children, and steal away to the wilderness. We’d always end up here. Together. That much I’m sure of.

My hand slips away from her mouth because I need to taste her. I need to convey with a brutal, claiming kiss that she’s mine, that she’ll always be mine. Our tongues thrash together in a frantic dance only the two of us know the steps to. I fuck her hard and relentlessly.

She’s mine.

Mine. Mine. Fucking mine.

I grind my hips so that my pelvis rubs against hers, putting pressure on her throbbing clit as I fuck her. It doesn’t take long before Devon gasps for air, her pleasure threatening to launch her into the stars. All it takes is a feral nip at her bottom lip for her to come with a garbled shriek. Her pussy squeezes around my cock, and I’m done for.

“Fuck,” I growl as my balls seize tight, and I begin spurting my thick seed into her body. “Fuck you’re always so goddamn perfect, Pip. You’re mine. In all the worlds, in all the ways, in all the versions of you. You belong to me, body, heart, and motherfucking soul.”

This time our kiss is sweeter. Less desperate and filled with pure love. I keep moving my hips in a slow cadence despite having drained my cock moments before. We’re best like this—together as one.

Eventually, when her body turns boneless and her thighs relax, falling apart, I rest my larger body against her tiny one. My lips find her neck, and I lick the salty skin there, nuzzling her damp hair with my nose. Despite turning flaccid, my cock remains inside her, keeping the remnants of our lovemaking trapped inside her. If I could spend my days just like this, I would.

This is my heaven.

She is my heaven.

Her fingers lazily draw shapes on my shoulders and upper back before sliding into my hair. I groan at the comforting sensation. My mouth latches onto her neck, and I suck on her flesh, unable to keep from marking her. She doesn't stop me, even though the kids might ask her about the bruises tomorrow. My wife lets me suck and suck and suck until the entire side of her neck is soaked and claimed by me.

When I've thoroughly given her neck enough attention, my dick slides out of her as I slowly kiss my way over her tits, spending plenty of time there. I kiss her stomach and every silvery scar my children left on her before finding her pussy. She whimpers when I push her thighs apart, revealing her red, slick lower lips. My cum leaks out of her slowly. With my finger, I drag a rivulet of my cum back into her opening, boldly pushing it back into her.

She cries out when I give her pussy an open-mouthed kiss. I suck on her clit that's swollen and then lave at the juices running back out of her. It's salty and tastes like me, which soothes my inner beast.

My dick, though throbbing with pleasure, doesn't bounce back like it did in my younger days. It doesn't stop me from giving Devon another orgasm, though. She whimpers and sighs as I lick her pussy into a second soul-shattering explosion. This time, she's nearly asleep by the time she recovers from the bliss.

I slide away to grab her discarded towel and clean her up. Then, I turn off the bedside lamp before sliding my body around hers. It's still too hot to cover up with blankets, but it doesn't stop me from tucking her back against my chest and pulling her tight against me.

"Love you, Pip."

"Love you too," she rasps, a smile in her voice, "*Daddy*."

For fuck's sake.

And I thought my dick couldn't get hard twice in one night ever again.

"Devon," I warn in an authoritative growl.

She laughs quietly, enjoying her effect on me. We eventually both grow silent, and I'm pretty sure she's asleep when she speaks again.

"I just want to keep them all safe. Are we doing the right thing?"

"At this point, we're doing the only thing we know how to do."

"What's that?"

"Love them with everything we have and protect them with all we've got."

"Will it be enough?"

"It has to be," I murmur. "Now, go to sleep, Pip. Tomorrow will be a better day."

"Pinky swear?"

I hook her pinky with mine and kiss her shoulder. "Pinky swear."

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